



ABOUT TIME: *Race* (left) and *Khuda Kay Liye* have fared well at the box office in Pakistan and India respectively



Changing Direction

Commerce worked where diplomacy didn't as India and Pakistan begin to watch each other's movies, in theatres

This figure alone tells the story of the Pakistani film industry—there are 20,000 video and DVD parlours in Pakistan and 270 screens. Much of the video rental business survives on Indian cinema, and it's no surprise that Bollywood has been eyeing its neighbour for some time now, hoping to create another Gulf. Already the Gulf market provides 40 per cent of Bollywood's overseas territory business—the diaspora contributes 25 per cent to the total box office gross. Four recent Indian films have been released in quick succession in Pakistan, with 15 prints each (compared to an average 25 in the Gulf). Their combined business has been over Rs 5 crore.

The detente has taken a long time to come. Pakistan banned Indian films in 1965, though it has exempted films such as *Mughal-e-Azam* and *Taj Mahal*. Last year, *Awaarapan* became the first Indian film to be released simultaneously in both the countries, making Rs 2.5 crore on an 18-print release, establishing Emraan Hashmi as a star in Pakistan. It was the culmination of Mahesh and Mukesh Bhatt's assiduous courting of Pakistan, which began with their regular attendance at

the Kara Film Festival since 2003, embracing Pakistani music with Atif Aslam in *Zehar* in 2005 and even showcasing Pakistani actor Meera in their disastrous *Nazar* the same year.

Other production houses have followed their lead and are exploiting Pakistan's regulations that say films, more than 50 per cent of which are shot outside India, or are produced by companies more than 50 per cent of whose ownership rests with non-Indians, can apply to the Central Film Censor Board of Pakistan. This is what qualified UTV's *Race* and *Goal* and Indian Films' *Welcome*. An exception was made for

Taare Zameen Par because of its subject, which UTV is now hoping will be applied to *Jodhaa Akbar* as well.

The slow but steady progress of Bollywood hasn't gone down well with everyone in the Pakistani film industry though which is muttering dark threats about creeping cultural imperialism. But the Film Producers' Association and Cinema Owners' Association hope it will revive the cinema-going habit—more than 800 theatres have been shut down in Pakistan in the past 20 years and there has been a slowing down of film production from 200 movies a year (same as Bollywood) in 1970s to just 40.

India has also shown reciprocity in releasing Pakistani films. *Khuda Kay Liye*, a highly feted Shoaib Mansoor film, was released by Percept Pictures last month, with 107 prints, which the company wants to raise to 300. Last week, another distributor, Innovision, tried to cash in by releasing *Salakhein* with 25 prints. Unlike in Pakistan though, there are no restrictions to importing films here. Pakistani films are free to apply to the Central Board of Film Certification directly.

Will such an exchange end Pakistan's flourishing piracy business (an estimate puts the loss for Bollywood at Rs 200 crore a year) and more importantly, gladden the hearts of the Track II-wallahs? It's one film-ending worth waiting for. **by Kaveree Bamzai**

FLICKERING ACT

- Pakistan had banned screenings of Indian films in 1965.
- Indian filmmakers are now exploiting loopholes in Pakistani import regulations.
- Every year, Bollywood loses around Rs 200 crore due to flourishing piracy in Pakistan.
- India recently screened *Khuda Kay Liye*, an import from Lollywood.